media. But it was also abundantly clear that Indians responded en masse because their government, our government, has not been responsive to their needs or fears or aspirations.

As a result, lakhs of deprived, marginalized and oppressed communities rushed to the Yatra, just to share their stories and pain. And Rahul really responded well, going beyond just receiving applications and petitions. Using hugs as a means of communication (irrespective of people's caste, religion, gender or class), he gained widespread love from the people. Exemplifying the Marathi couplet '*kar maje julati* (folding my hands)', the Yatra transcended all artificial boundaries, offering a glimpse of what true unity can look like. Several significant and small issues surfaced during the Yatra, constantly reshaping its overall goals and purpose. For example, during the lockdown, we all saw heart-wrenching stories of hundreds of daily-wage labourers walking long distances with their families, carrying a child on their shoulders or a father on a bicycle, that the government tried hard to hide from the public gaze. In stark contrast, for months on end, people from different sections of society walked with Rahul, filling our hearts and making many an eye moist with happiness. The contrast between the two parties (the ruling dispensation and the Congress) was stark.

The Yatra was also about a young leader raising his party's flag high and rebuilding the somewhat dilapidated tower of the Congress. A number of local and national Congress leaders capitalized on the Yatra and Rahul Gandhi to showcase themselves. Not that they did something wrong, but it was a clever and subtle way to promote the Congress without pushing it overtly. For example, while the Tricolour remained the Yatra's symbol, it was also reminiscent of the colours raised by the Indian National Congress during the freedom movement. In this spirit, Rahul Gandhi must be lauded, for he continued to loyally promote the party even after stepping down from his post as party president. In each step he took, he was holding aloft the party's legacy on his shoulders. Can any other leader in the Congress boast such humility and devotion? Often once leaders demit an organizational post, they just stop working. But not Rahul. He led by example and showed an alternative path.